

For better or for worse, we decided to share, to prepare, to work together, to involve the whole family in our financial life, with trusts, an investment committee, a family constitution, budget goals and everything else the family office guidebooks recommend. We decided to burden the children with the fruits of our own lives. They are supposed to join in our key financial decisions, help manage family property, and partake in the family business. They're meant to help preserve and enhance the family wealth, such as it is.

Don't get the wrong idea. We're not taking the high road. We never like the high road; it makes us a little queasy. But we don't like the high life much, either. Spend our time playing golf? Fishing? Cruising around the world? Doesn't sound like much fun. And we have no interest in fancy cars or expensive clothes. We drive a Ford pick-up and wear what we get for Christmas.

So we've taken a different route. To us, it is more interesting, exciting, and challenging. And there's much less traffic.

But what's involved? What's it all about? What do you have to do?

First, let's begin with the basics. If you're going to have family money, you need two things. You need a family. And you need money.

There, that's simple enough.

But what kind of family? You'll find out more about that in the next chapter.

The other part of the formula is easier, at least in theory. Money is simple. It doesn't have contrary opinions. It doesn't talk back to you. It isn't ungrateful, spiteful, petty, envious, incompetent, moody—or any of the other things that can destroy a family. And it never goes through the teenage years. You can always work with money in a purely rational, logical way. Like an adult. No need to beat around the bush or use reverse psychology on money. It is as direct as a bullet and as simpleminded as a congressman. You can play it straight with money. You can use your left brain, just as you would if you were building a house or repairing a toaster.

Getting money ought to be easy. And it ought to be easy to hold on to it, too.

There are two main elements to human beings, said the ancient Greeks. Of course, the Greeks had their ideas. We have our own. In our view, the